FUGUE XVII

THIS Fugue, now one of the greatest in the forty-eight, was first written as a Fughetta in F major, ending at bar 24. In that form it was obvious that the burst of four-part writing in bars 22 and 23 meant a climax; and now that it is double its early length this Fugue still characteristically reserves the four-part passages for great moments, such as the entry of the bass with reversed accents in bar 37. The Fugue is written in Triple Counterpoint of Bach's usual type, the Subject with its varied rhythms and wide intervals being contrasted with two Countersubjects, the one a slow descending chromatic scale and the other a winding coil of semiquavers. This semiquaver counterpoint is, however, not always represented by the same notes throughout the Fugue. But its figure in bars 6-7 is established well enough to bear inverting as the basis of the important Episode of bars 10-14, a fresh piece of Triple Counterpoint which in the course of this Fugue goes through four of its six possible permutations. As far as the semiquaver Countersubject is preserved during the entries of the Subject, it is put into new harmonic positions, and thus (perhaps with no special design on Bach's part) presents the unusual combination of Double Counterpoint in the fourteenth (bars 22-24) and, as the rich added thirds prove, in the tenth (bars 32-33). The player will not fail to do justice to what was once the final climax in bars 22-23; and he will take particular care of the suspended G of the tenor which launches the Fugue into its larger career in bar 24. The Triple Counterpoint Episode re-enters in the middle of bar 27 (let the bass sing out sweetly to establish its identity with the top voice of bar 10). In bar 34 notice the premonitory figures of the Subject in the alto and soprano. Make them distinct in a *crescendo* which leads up to, without masking, the real entry in bar 35. This point is thus the opposite of that in bar 5, where the alto's allusion to the Subject must on no account be emphasised, it being abundantly clear so long as the notes are played at all. The reversed-accent entry of the bass in the subdominant in bar 37 is, as already mentioned, a big event, marked by a four-part harmony and leading to the firm and final re-establishment of the tonic. Mark the three descending steps of the semiquaver figures in the bass, across the accent, and downward in fourths, G♭, D♭, A♭ to E♭ in bar 40. The passage severely tests the player's singing tone in the First Countersubject. In bars 41-44 draw a long singing line over the slow chromatic descent of the soprano, and see what the outside fingers of the left hand can do by way of a powerful bass. The rest of the climax must fire the feeblest imagination; it even impresses the eye. In the five-part close (bars 48½-50) it is easy enough to bring out the Subject; the difficulty lies in the necessary emphasis on the First Countersubject below it. The *tempo* is a very moderate four, almost a swinging eight, so that the *ritardando* required for the last four bars need not be sudden or violent.

The British Museum autograph seems to have finer and later readings than that of this particular Fugue in the Berlin Royal Library, or than any other MS. It is therefore followed here without giving alternatives.

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